Westbrook City Council

~ Special Meeting ~

Date: Monday, July 20, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM (immediately following the Committee of the Whole)
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1211520585
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_07202026-1019

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Mayor's Message: Property Tax Bills

Final Tax Rate Lower Than Projected [1:12]

Discussion Summary

Mayor Morse announced finalized FY2027 property tax bills are being mailed, with the final tax-rate increase coming in at 6.6% — lower than the 7.6% estimated during spring budget deliberations — thanks to new growth added to the City's tax base. The resulting rate is $16.10 per $1,000 of assessed value. Each bill will include a letter explaining the rate, highlighting the budget's guiding principles (accountability, due diligence, and sustaining services), the City's success securing outside grant funding (citing the regional fire training facility, Riverwalk environmental cleanup, and landslide mitigation planning as examples funded without burdening local taxpayers), available tax-relief programs, and the ongoing effort to deepen City/School Department collaboration.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Mayor's Message: Landslide Vulnerability Assessment Project

Project Manager Robyn Saunders & Dr. Brenda Zollitsch Update [5:47]

Discussion Summary

The project traces to the September 2020 landslide along Warren Avenue, which affected over three acres, deposited debris into the river to form an artificial dam, and triggered a state of emergency over flood risk. The City subsequently secured $986,000 in congressionally directed federal spending plus $120,000 in state match from MaineDOT's Infrastructure Adaptation Fund — after two earlier funding applications were turned down because landslides weren't initially treated as a regional funding priority. The project is 100% non-taxpayer

funded, with roughly $95,180 remaining under a one-year MEMA extension so a University of Maine PhD candidate can finish analyzing 2025 soil samples.

The study covers a regional problem: the six municipalities of the Presumpscot River watershed (Westbrook, Portland, Falmouth, Gorham, Windham, and Standish) all bought into the funding application, and the underlying issue — sensitive marine clays prone to landslide activity — extends from the southern New Hampshire border north to the Penobscot River. Councilor McCambridge noted Westbrook is effectively a "trailblazer" on this issue regionally.

Dr. Zollitsch's team has completed a roughly 112-page draft national/regional policy scan (covering the U.S., Maritime Canada, and Quebec), is finishing ten stakeholder interviews feeding a forthcoming "viewpoints analysis" report, and is now conducting a formal trade-offs analysis (Bardach's methodology) to narrow policy options. Public/stakeholder engagement is expected by fall 2026; the grant period runs through September 30, 2027, with three or four more Council updates planned before then.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

City Council Messages

Statement on Biddeford Incident [24:46]

Discussion Summary

President Munro addressed the recent killing of Mr. Juan Guerrero in Biddeford, expressing solidarity with Westbrook's immigrant community, voicing concern over the fear such incidents create, and encouraging residents to contact their state and federal legislators.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational — no vote taken.

Action Items

None.

Orders of the Day — Second & Final Reading

Order 2026-78 — Vallee Square Emergency Sewer Repair (Final Reading) [28:31]

Found on page 15 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Confirms $70,078.48 in emergency sewer-repair expenditures at Vallee Square, first read July 6, 2026 — see that meeting's summary for full background on the grease-collapsed pipe.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

New Business — Orders (One Reading Required)

Order 2026-79 — Pierce Street Closure for Water Main Replacement [28:31]

Found on page 23 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes closure of Pierce Street (Cumberland Street to Whitney Avenue) to through traffic for two days during the week of August 17, 2026, 7 AM–5 PM, plus a one-lane alternating closure on Cumberland Street, for a water main replacement project; the exact closure date will be finalized one week prior, with public notice to residents, following the same flexible-scheduling approach used for the earlier Spring Street closure.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

[31:39] ***Order 2026-80 — Mountain Division Trail: MDOT/PACTS Endorsement.*** *Formally endorses submitting the Westbrook-to-Windham segment of the Mountain Division Trail (Bridge Street to Route 202 in Windham) to the Portland Area Comprehensive Transportation System (PACTS) and MaineDOT for the 2027–2029 work plan.*

> *"The trail considered here runs only 150 yards from my house... I ask you to move this trail plan forward tonight... please realize that there's still this gap between Bridge Street and Main Street... I urge you to hasten creating that plan to fill in that gap."*

— David Von Seggern (51 Emory St., public comment) [25:57]

Councilors clarified the City is pursuing two paths simultaneously: this endorsement supports building the trail beside the existing rail corridor, while a separate, slower Rail Use Advisory Council (RUAC) process could allow the trail to be built within the rail bed instead — cheaper and smaller-footprint, but taking roughly two years for review plus a redesign. Staff said advancing both tracks pressures MaineDOT to engage and choose a direction rather than let the ~$16 million project stall. Two historic culverts along the route (classified as bridges under DOT standards) need separate repair funding, estimated at $1–1.5 million each. This endorsement does not commit Westbrook to its ~10% local match (~$800,000). Windham has already endorsed the same application.

Key Decisions

✓ Order 2026-80 passed by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

New Business — Orders (First Reading, Two Readings Required)

Order 2026-81 — Colonial Road Pump Station Driveway Repair [40:45]

Found on page 49 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Authorizes a $24,300 agreement with J.A. Ricci & Sons (an approved paving vendor) to repair the Colonial Road pump station driveway, including an exposed water meter currently protruding through the pavement. Councilor Shaughnessy thanked the City for using a local vendor with community ties.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 7–0 (first reading).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-82 — Fire Department SCBA Air Compressor [42:53]

Found on page 52 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Awards a $107,170 bid to Harrison Schrader Enterprises for a replacement SCBA (self-contained breathing apparatus) air compressor, part of the FY2026 Capital Improvement Plan. Staff lowered the original ~$110,970 bid by handling old-unit disposal in-house and using Corey Electric for associated electrical work; the balance above the CIP allocation comes from unspent Gas Meter CIP funds ($7,817) and Fire Reserves ($11,353).

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 7–0 (first reading).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-83 — Replacement Aerial Bucket Truck [46:00]

Found on page 72 of the packet.

Discussion Summary

Awards a $170,519.85 bid to Palfinger North America for a replacement 45-foot aerial bucket truck (5 feet taller than the current unit), replacing a 2010 truck needing ~$39,000 in repairs. The City passed over the single lowest bid, which assumed a trade-in credit staff believe the old unit will exceed at auction instead; the $5,519.80 above the original $165,000 CIP allocation comes from unspent single-axle plow truck CIP funds.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed by unanimous show of hands, 7–0 (first reading).

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-84: Student Transit Pass Program (6–1)

[48:51] Authorizes an agreement with the Greater Portland Transit District (Metro) to provide every Westbrook High School student a free, unlimited-travel transit pass, capped at 30,000 rides/year and $1.13 per ride actually taken (maximum annual cost $34,000). Mayor Morse gave an extended endorsement, framing it as both a near-term mobility benefit and a long-term investment in building transit habits, funded entirely by new General Fund revenue from a previously untapped source: the City recently completed state certification to process rental-vehicle registrations (e.g., for Enterprise) locally, identified by Interim Finance Director Laura King.

Principal Garrett explained the school-specific motivation: roughly 110 ninth- and tenth-graders live within Westbrook High School's 1.5-mile walking radius (too close to qualify for school bus service, often too far to walk safely), and Metro has agreed to add a new stop (Stroudwater & Monroe) on existing Route 3 during morning/afternoon windows only, not a new route. He estimated 50–100 daily student riders once established.

Discussion covered several concerns:

• **Revenue certainty:** Councilor McCambridge questioned relying on untested rental-registration revenue before committing to the cost; staff said early estimates suggest revenue will substantially exceed the program's cost, with updates to follow.
• **Neighborhood impact:** Councilor Rairdon raised traffic/bus-speed concerns on Monroe Street, a quiet residential street gaining a new stop, and asked that residents be notified well before the August 3 second reading.
• **Student safety/privacy:** Councilor Turcotte asked whether passes would be physical cards or app-based, flagging data-security concerns for minors; staff agreed to bring more detail before second reading.
• **Scope:** Councilor McCambridge confirmed the program covers all WHS students, not just the walking-radius zone, and proposed a voluntary “ride the bus” familiarization event before the school year; Principal Garrett welcomed the idea.
• **Possible added costs:** Councilor Chau asked whether the new stop could trigger additional ADA complementary paratransit costs beyond the $34,000 cap; staff believed any impact would be minimal but agreed to confirm.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed 6–1 by show of hands (first reading); the transcript does not identify the dissenting councilor by name.

Closing

Second Public Comment, Referrals, Committee Reports & Adjournment [1:17:24]

Discussion Summary

No second public comment, no referrals, no committee report updates, and no executive session. Meeting adjourned by unanimous show of hands.

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to adjourn approved by show of hands.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names and figures against the official packet and the city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the presiding officer) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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